



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 09/01/2025	Entry: #1
ransomware	Several targeted phishing emails were sent and clicked on by employees. The malicious attachment deployed ransomware. All company files are encrypted, and a large sum of money was demanded for the decryption key. This incident would most likely fall under the detection and analysis phase of NIST Incident response lifecycle because ransomware and ransom note was detected.
Tool(s) used	Encryption
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? An organized group of unethical hackers who target healthcare and transportation industries are who caused the incident. • What happened? Targeted phishing emails were sent, several employees clicked on a malicious attachment and installed the malware once downloaded, then attackers deployed their ransomware and left a note demanding payment for the decryption key. • When did the incident occur? It occurred on Tuesday morning at 9am.

	• Where did the incident happen? It happened at a small US healthcare clinic. • Why did the incident happen? The incident happened because security awareness training was not in place, which led to several employees clicking on a malicious attachment from targeted phishing emails.
Additional notes	Did the company plan on paying the ransom? Was any backups created, if so were they encrypted as well?

Date: 02/24/2026	Entry: #2
Phishing	A malicious password protected attachment was sent to an employee. The employee downloaded and opened a malicious file. A trojan was deployed and created several unauthorized executable files on the laptop. This would be the detection and analysis phase of the NIST incident response lifecycle because the incident was detected by IDS and analyzed with SHA256 hash and VirusTotal and confirmed it was malicious.
Tool(s) used	Hash function, VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? A threat actor caused the incident by deceiving an employee. • What happened? The employee received an email with a suspicious password protected spreadsheet attachment and the password. They downloaded the attachment, entered the password and it executed a malicious payload.

	• When did the incident occur? The employee received the email at 1:11pm and successfully downloaded and opened the file at 1:13pm. • Where did the incident happen? The incident happened on the employee's computer. • Why did the incident happen? The employee downloaded and opened a suspicious file.
Additional notes	• SHA256 file hash: 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b • The hash was identified as malicious on virustotal. Commonly identified as a trojan. 58/72 security vendor ratio and -289 virustotal community score. • By 1:15pm multiple unauthorized executables were created on the employee's laptop. By 1:20pm IDS detects executables and sends out an alert.

Date: 03/02/2026	Entry: #3
Alert ticket	Responding to a phishing incident. A phishing email was sent with a malicious attachment to HR. The attachment was downloaded onto the employees computer. The incident occurred in the detection and analysis phase of the incident response lifecycle because the incident was detected by indicators of compromise and an alert ticket and analyzed with SHA256 hash analysis and VirusTotal.
Tool(s) used	Hash function, Virustotal, Phishing playbook
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident.

	• Who caused the incident? A threat actor possibly impersonating Clyde West. • What happened? A phishing email with malicious attachment was sent to HR at Inergy and successfully downloaded. • When did the incident occur? The incident occurred on Wednesday, July 20, 2022 at 09:30:14 AM. • Where did the incident happen? The incident happened on the employee's computer. • Why did the incident happen? The employee clicked and successfully downloaded the malicious attachment.
Additional notes	• Known malicious file hash: 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b • The senders IP address: <114.114.114.114> • Sender's information: Def Communications <76tguyhh6tgfrt7tg.su> • Sender's name and email doesn't match • Employee IP address: <176.157.125.93> • Employee information: <hr@inergy.com> • The email contained grammatical errors • The password to open malicious attachment was: paradise10789 • Attachment: filename="bfsvc.exe"

Date: 03/09/2026	Entry: #4
Exfiltrated PII	An individual gained unauthorized access to customer PII and financial information. About 50,000 customer records were affected. The potential loss of revenue and direct costs is \$100,000. This incident occurred in the detection and analysis phase of the incident response lifecycle because the ransom email was detected along with a sample of exfiltrated data and reported to the

	security team. The security team then conducted an investigation.
Tool(s) used	Forced browsing attack, web app logs, web server logs
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? An attacker/threat actor caused the incident. • What happened? On December 22nd, the threat actor sent an email demanding \$25,000 payment for exfiltrated customer data. He sent another email on December 28th that included a sample of customer data and raised the demand price to \$50,000. The security team was notified and an investigation was conducted between December 28-31. • When did the incident occur? December 28, 2022, at 7:20 p.m., PT, • Where did the incident happen? The incident happened on the company's e-commerce site. • Why did the incident happen? The threat actor exploited a web application vulnerability by using a forced browsing attack.
Additional notes	50,000 customer records were affected. Financial impact was \$100,000 in direct costs and potential loss of revenue. The data breach was disclosed, they offered free identity protection services to customers affected by the incident. The vulnerability allowed the attacker to access customer purchase confirmation pages exposing customer data that was collected and exfiltrated. A single log showed high volume listed customer orders. They implemented access control mechanisms and performed routine vulnerability scans and penetration testing to prevent future occurrences.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • What happened? • When did the incident occur? • Where did the incident happen? • Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

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Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?
The wazuh setup activity was surprisingly difficult. I had to find missing steps not included in the guide, like gaining root privileges to input commands. I used a combination of google searches and youtube tutorials to complete the task.
2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course? Yes, my understanding of incident response and detection has improved. At first I thought it was about reacting to incidents. Now I understand how documentation helps in gathering data, analyzing incidents and coming up with solutions. I learned how to detect incidents using indicators of compromise and IDS.
3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why? The specific tool I enjoyed the most was virustotal because it allowed me to quickly check if a file is malicious. I also enjoyed the incident handler's journal because it showed me how helpful documentation is during incidents. The incident response lifecycle and playbooks helped me to really understand how to identify and respond to different phases of an incident.